

Snakes

Suborder Serpentes

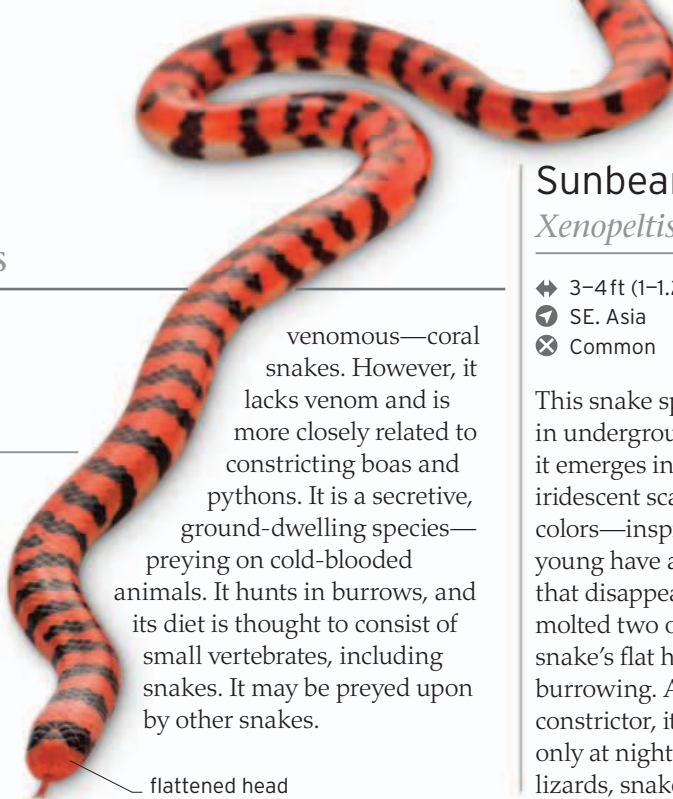
South American pipe snake

Anilius scytale

- ↔ 28–35 in (70–90 cm)
- 📍 SE. US
- ⊗ Vulnerable

The sole member of the family Aniliidae, this snake of the Amazon basin, is also called the “false coral snake” due to its superficial resemblance to the vividly colored—and highly

venomous—coral snakes. However, it lacks venom and is more closely related to constricting boas and pythons. It is a secretive, ground-dwelling species—preying on cold-blooded animals. It hunts in burrows, and its diet is thought to consist of small vertebrates, including snakes. It may be preyed upon by other snakes.



flattened head

Sunbeam snake

Xenopeltis unicolor

- ↔ 3–4 ft (1–1.2 m)
- 📍 SE. Asia
- ⊗ Common

This snake spends much of its time in underground burrows, but when it emerges into sunlight, its iridescent scales shine with many colors—inspiring its name. The young have a distinctive white color that disappears once the skin has molted two or three times. This snake’s flat head may help with burrowing. An egg-laying constrictor, it comes above ground only at night and preys on frogs, lizards, snakes, and small mammals.

Rainbow boa

Epicrates cenchria

- ↔ 3–7 ft (1–2.1 m)
- 📍 Central and South America
- ⊗ Not known

Named for the colored sheen of its skin, the rainbow boa is a typical muscular constrictor. Its color varies across its range from plain brown to a pattern of orange, red, and black, depending upon subspecies. The back has black circles, while the flanks have light-centered spots. It climbs into low vegetation, but also inhabits open savanna. Like other boas, this snake bears live young, sometimes producing litters of over 20.

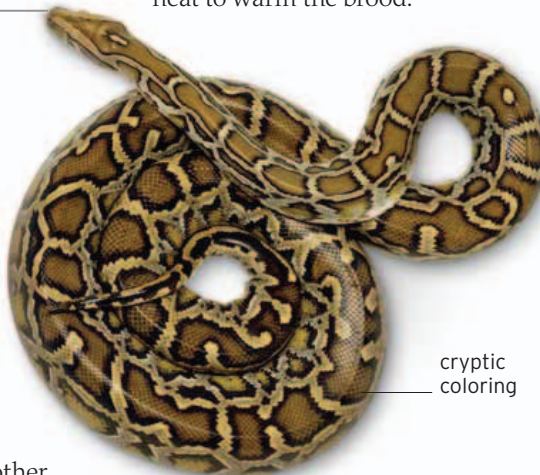
Burmese python

Python bivittatus

- ↔ 16–23 ft (5–7 m)
- 📍 S. and SE. Asia
- ⊗ Vulnerable

One of the biggest of the Old World pythons, the Burmese python climbs well and swims—despite its bulk. Full-grown pythons can overpower pigs and goats—and backward-pointing teeth help grip the victim for swallowing whole. Like other

pythons, this species lays eggs. The female vibrates her body to generate heat to warm the brood.



cryptic coloring

Common egg-eating snake

Dasypeltis scabra

- ↔ 28–39 in (70–100 cm)
- 📍 Africa and W. Asia
- ⊗ Common

This toothless snake has a special feeding technique. Flexible jaws and throat allow it to swallow hard-shelled eggs whole—even ones wider than its head. Once in the throat, bony projections of the snake’s spine puncture the shell, so the yolk and white can flow into the digestive system. The crushed remains of the shell are regurgitated.



Boomslang

Dispholidus typus

- ↔ 3–6 ft (1–1.8 m)
- 📍 Sub-Saharan Africa
- ⊗ Not known

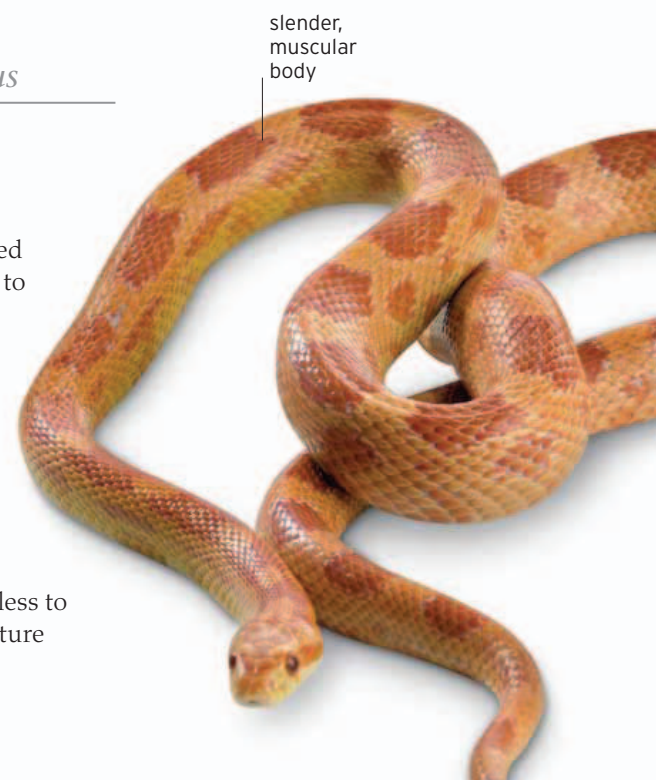
One of the most potentially venomous of all climbing snakes, the boomslang—meaning “tree snake” in Afrikaans—spends much of its life among branches. Here, its agility and good binocular vision help it prey on climbing lizards, mammals, and birds during the day. It has large rear fangs and a wide gape. Its venom causes internal bleeding that can quickly lead to death. Females lay clutches of up to 14 eggs in tree hollows and dead vegetation.

Corn snake

Pantherophis guttatus

- ↔ 3–6 ft (1–1.8 m)
- 📍 C. and SE. US
- ⊗ Common

The corn snake is so-called because it is often drawn to caches of corn and grain, where it kills rats and mice by constriction and can be effective at pest control. It is common in the eastern US, and in colder, northern parts of its range it hibernates during winter. This non-venomous snake is harmless to humans and its docile nature makes it a popular pet.



slender, muscular body